United Kingdom Liaison Mission in Japan,
TOKYO.

F29

SECRET

No. 15
(1030/41/52)

28th January, 1952.

FJ 10310/38

Sir,

I attempt in this despatch to estimate the consequences of the action taken by the United States in persuading the Japanese Prime Minister to publish his letter of 24th December expressing the readiness of Japan to conclude a treaty with Chiang Kai-shek and to have no dealings with the Communist régime in China. It is true that this estimate can only be a matter of conjecture based upon experience. But I hope I do not exaggerate when I express the opinion that this American action is something which we shall all have cause to regret in the future, and not least the Americans themselves.

2. The consequences of this step are likely to be felt, first, in the Japanese internal political situation, secondly in the Far Eastern situation generally and lastly in the Korean conflict. All these are, of course, to some extent inter-related.

3. There can be little doubt that the position of the Prime Minister will be much weakened by the action which he felt compelled to take. It is common knowledge that he did not consult his Cabinet colleagues before reaching the decision to publish the letter and that he merely told them just before the event. The odium of having given way to what is generally regarded as American dictation must therefore fall upon him personally, and his political stature must be judged to have shrunk. He has undoubtedly displayed considerable ineptitude in the handling of this affair from the outset. The situation might never have arisen if he had not given utterance to indiscreet statements in the Diet when ratification of the Peace Treaty was being debated. Subsequently he took the stand that Japan could not take any action in regard to China in the absence of Anglo-American agreement. Though this may have been regarded, particularly by the Americans, as a mere evasion of the issue, it would probably have had a good deal of support in Japan. But Mr. Yoshida then abandoned this attitude and adopted a policy which no Japanese regards as in Japan's best interests without any public explanation of the reasons which led him to make such a decision. Such reputation as he possessed has undoubtedly suffered as a result.

4/

His Majesty's Principal Secretary of State
for Foreign Affairs,

Foreign Office.

Reference:-
FO 371/96404
PUBLIC RECORD OFFICE
COPYRIGHT - NOT TO BE REPRODUCED PHOTOGRAPHICALLY WITHOUT PERMISSION

4. The Session of the Diet which has now been resumed may well prove to be a stormy one, though it is possible that the full weight of any attack upon Mr. Yoshida will not develop until the United States Senate has ratified the Treaty. But there is a fair prospect that the Diet will still be in session when the Treaty comes into force and Japan becomes fully sovereign, and it may well be that thereafter there will be less restraint in attacking Mr. Yoshida and his administration. In all the circumstances, he would probably be wise in his own interests to resign at that stage and to disappear from politics. But Mr. Yoshida has not shown himself to be very wise, and there is no knowing what he will do. If he goes, the average Japanese will probably take the view that Mr. Yoshida did what he did in order not to jeopardise the Peace Treaty, and that by resigning he accepted responsibility in the best Japanese tradition; in fact that he was a true patriot. If he stays, however, the view may be very different once the Treaty is in force.

5. The fact is, however, that the Americans by their action have weakened the very Government which they have pronounced themselves as supporting. The stigma of being a lackey of the Americans is one which will attach increasingly to any Japanese politician who can be shown to have accepted American dictation. A weapon has been put in the hands of the reactionaries, whether of the Right or Left, and it is by no means certain that the present form of government will survive the unpopularity it will incur if it is compelled to succumb to American pressure to the extent of adopting policies which are not in Japan's interests. I warned Mr. Dulles in December of the danger of weakening the Japanese Government in this way, but what I had to say apparently fell on deaf ears.

6. The effect upon China of the Yoshida letter may in the short term be worse than in Japan. For it has always seemed to me that Japan is a much more serious issue with China than it is with Russia. It has surely been significant in recent months that such conciliatory gestures as there have been towards Japan have come from Russia and not from China. As far as one is able to judge, China's main fear has been the building up of Japan by the United States to a point where the former can once again become a serious rival in the Far East. The public alignment of Japan on the question of China with the United States by the Yoshida letter can only serve to strengthen China's fears and to confirm her in the views which she has consistently and publicly expressed. Mr. Yoshida's dream of Japan acting as a bridge between Communist China and the free world has vanished, and seems most unlikely ever to become a reality.— I think all Japanese as a result of the Yoshida letter view the future of Japan's relations with China with considerable misgiving, and not without reason.

I/

Reference: FO 371/96404
PUBLIC RECORD OFFICE
COPYRIGHT - NOT TO BE REPRODUCED PHOTOGRAPHICALLY WITHOUT PERMISSION

I consider that the general outlook in the Far East is more serious as a result of the United States action, and it is difficult to see that any remedy can now be applied.

7. It is possible also that the Yoshida letter will have an adverse effect upon the Korean armistice negotiations. If we accept that China has always been profoundly and genuinely distrustful of United States intentions, the letter can only have heightened such distrust. If China should regard it as further evidence that the United States is busily engaged in building up a hostile front with the intention of bringing about the downfall of the present régime in Peking, it seems to me that her views about the desirability of an armistice in Korea might change, and that a prolongation of the conflict might seem the better alternative. While Japan was, so to speak, suspended between the two Chinas there may have been some inducement for the Peking Government to exercise moderation in the hope of ultimately drawing Japan into her orbit. The Yoshida letter can surely only have the result of cementing the Sino-Soviet Treaty of 14th February, 1950. China may now consider that the first sentence of Article I of that Treaty is applicable to the present situation, and may seek further Russian military assistance with a view to resuming the offensive in Korea. It appears that the view is beginning to be held in General Headquarters in Tokyo that the Chinese no longer want an armistice. I hope this may prove to be wrong, and that my conjectures as to Chinese reasoning are faulty. At the same time, the Yoshida letter will hardly dispose China to be more conciliatory in the Korean armistice negotiations, and if in the event they do make concessions to break the present deadlock, they must want an armistice more than we had supposed.

FF1019/25

8. At the end of my despatch No. 375 of 26th November I expressed some confidence about the future. That confidence is unlikely to be justified if the free world is to witness further unilateral action by the United States in respect of Japan which can only lead to a steady deterioration in the situation.

9. I am sending copies of this despatch to His Majesty's Ambassadors at Washington and Moscow, His Majesty's Chargé d'Affaires at Peking, and the Commissioner-General for His Majesty's Government in the United Kingdom in South-East Asia at Singapore.

I have the honour to be, with the highest respect,
Sir,
Your most obedient, humble Servant,

Reference:
FO 371/99404
PUBLIC RECORD OFFICE
COPYRIGHT - NOT TO BE REPRODUCED PHOTOGRAPHICALLY WITHOUT PERMISSION

P.S. Since I drafted this despatch last week press reports have appeared saying that "Pravda" has announced in Moscow that Russia would fight beside China if ever it was felt that China "was being attacked by the Japanese or by any forces allied with the Japanese." It appears therefore that the Yoshida letter has already had the effect which I forecast in paragraph 7 above.

Reference:-
FO 371/99404
PUBLIC RECORD OFFICE
COPYRIGHT - NOT TO BE REPRODUCED PHOTOGRAPHICALLY WITHOUT PERMISSION